Mini-whiteboards

Checking everyone's understanding

Make every student’s answer visible, identify gaps and decide what to teach next. Useful before independent practice or whenever answers from a few students leave you unsure about everyone else.

How to do it well

1 Plan a revealing question. Target one idea, anticipate plausible wrong answers and choose a word, calculation, sketch or choice that can be scanned.

2 Rehearse the mechanics. Model clear writing, private answers, boards facing you and erasing only on signal; practise with an easy question.

3 Secure independent thinking. Give response instructions before the question, allow time and keep boards hidden until commitment is complete.

4 Collect every response. Reveal together and scan systematically. If revealing back to front, everyone stops writing before the first row shows.

5 Probe and respond. Look for common errors and missing responses, ask how selected students decided, then Pause & Fix, Adapt & Support or Extend & Challenge as the evidence warrants.

What this sounds like

“One formula, written large. Keep it hidden. Write the formula for magnesium chloride.” [Thinking time.] “Pens down. Show me in three, two, one. Hold still while I check.”

Classroom example. Several Chemistry boards show MgCl rather than $MgCl_2$. The teacher keeps the responses private until all pupils commit, identifies the pattern and re-models charge balance. Pupils then answer a different ionic formula question. Correcting the original board alone would have shown compliance with the model rather than independent application.

Top tips that make the technique work

Separate working from the answer. Use one side for working and the other for a large final answer; turn it over when explaining the method.

Bring bookwork onto boards. Transfer the answer to one pivotal book question onto a board, then scan before showing the solution.

Investigate blank boards. Ask what the student knows or which part is unclear; offer a starting prompt and return.

Control public answers. Avoid praising an early correct board while others are writing; gather the evidence before revealing the solution.

Keep the routine available. Working pens, erasers and boards should be within reach; re-model premature erasing or unreadable answers.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Scan every response before giving the answer.	Accepting the first correct board as evidence for everyone.
Probe reasoning and use a fresh check after repair.	Using boards to rank students or as punishment.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED Mini-whiteboards revisited | Barton Top five tips

Barton Detailed routines | Barton Back row first